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Cover Letter

Dear Hiring Team,

For the past year, I've been building things that live at very different ends of the software spectrum (backend for a social app, security research, and a music analysis hackathon project) and from my chats with current developers at Google, it seems that this internship is the perfect place for someone like me who likes to experiment across different fields and not box themselves into labels. Most of my time these days goes into two internships that couldn't be more different from each other. At Clustr, I've spent the past several months building out the backend for a React Native social app (Firebase cloud functions, permissions logic, auth flows). The unglamorous stuff that holds the app together and has disastrous consequences for every mistake. At Prenora Dynamics, I've been given full rein for my little subsection of the app: a video chat feature that I have to design from scratch. I've spent a lot of time reading SDK docs and making judgment calls with no one telling me what the right answer is. Across these two internships, I've gotten comfortable with Python, JavaScript, TypeScript, and Java.

However, when somebody asks me about an interesting project I've done, my go-to is the research I've done with Ethos Lab. I designed a system that watches for newly issued SSL certificates and flags sites impersonating toll-payment services like EZ-Pass before they can scam anyone. It was a small two-person team and a lot of the work was tedious. We were writing Selenium scripts to scrape sites, building out heuristics, and staring at hundreds of domains to determine real fraud from noise. This coming Fall, I'll be joining a new research lab on Automotive Ethics: I'll be building out driving and traffic scenario simulations to study how self-driving systems should make ethical decisions in the moment. It is going to be a multi-semester commitment until I graduate and I'm looking forward to it as it is a departure from the fullstack work that I've been doing.

Something that has been very important to me throughout my life is the role I serve within my community. The year I've spent mentoring and working one-on-one with international students adjusting to life here in the States has been one of the most fulfilling jobs I've had and I'm looking forward to continuing that work this year. I volunteered to become a TA for a Data Structures & Algorithms course for the same reasons. Hosting weekly recitations where I was able to help students in a closer-knit environment was a challenging, yet fulfilling experience. I learned that there's a lot more to life than just stacking personal achievements. True fulfillment for me comes from the service of others, and that's the mindset I adopt with the code I write and the problems I solve.

Thank you for the opportunity, and I'll be looking forward to hearing back from you.

Sincerely,

Hein Zarni Aung